WEIGHT 09

Naltrexone

Opioid antagonist that blocks the brain's opioid receptors; for weight, approved only with bupropion



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Opioid antagonist	Alcohol, opioid use, weight	Large trials; FDA approved	FDA approved (Revia, Vivitrol); weight: Contrave

STUDIED FOR

Alcohol dependence	Opioid dependence	Body weight
HUMAN	HUMAN	HUMAN

Weight use alone is off-label. For weight, FDA approved naltrexone only combined with bupropion, as Contrave (2014).

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Naltrexone ▶ Opioid receptors ▶ Opioids blocked ▶ Craving, appetite

- **Blocks opioid receptors,** so opioids taken while on it have little effect
- **With bupropion,** lab and animal data point to the hypothalamus and reward system
- **In lab studies,** the pair raised firing of appetite-regulating POMC cells
- **Contrave label:** the exact effects behind weight loss are not fully understood

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

FDA APPROVED
LEVEL 5 OF 5

- Contrave: 4 COR trials, 4,536 adults, 56 weeks
- Dose-finding trial vs naltrexone alone: 419 adults
- Approved for addiction since 1984

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Contrave effect on heart disease

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE	ROUTES STUDIED
About 4 hours; 6-β-naltrexol 13 hours (tablet label)	By mouth (tablets); monthly injection (Vivitrol)
PHARMACOKINETICS	**SOLD AS**
Peak within 1 hour; main metabolite 6-β-naltrexol; kidney excretion	Prescription tablets, injection (Vivitrol); Contrave
MONITORED IN TRIALS	**SPORT (WADA)**
Liver injury signs; mood and suicidal thoughts (Contrave)	Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	Approved: Revia 1984, Vivitrol 2006, Contrave 2014
DEA	Not a controlled substance
EMA	Mysimba: heart safety past 12 months uncertain
WADA	Not prohibited

REFERENCES

1. FDA, Naltrexone hydrochloride tablets prescribing information, Sep 2026
2. FDA, Contrave prescribing information, Nov 2025
3. Nissen et al., LIGHT trial, JAMA, Mar 2016

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